

Letters of a Shield Brother in Times of Turmoil

First Letter — By the Firelight of Jorrvaskr

Brother, tonight I drank with the others in the long hall. The laughter was loud, the cups full, the stories greater than usual. And yet, beneath that noise, I felt the pulse of something older. Not the drum of war. Not the song of heroes. But the call of the hunt. Primal instincts passed down by our ancestors.. When I look into the fire, I do not see a gift. I see a promise made too quickly.

Second Letter — On the Fate of Heroes

They teach us that to die with a sword in hand is glory. That the halls of heroes welcome the valiant. That the memory of a righteous life is stronger than death. But what welcomes one who has run as an animal? If my soul has learned to snarl more than to sing, where will it be taken when my heart stops? Among the ancestors... or among the shadows that hunt forever? They tell me it does not matter. That strength justifies the price. I am beginning to believe the price is the most important part.

Third Letter — On the Old Code

I have studied the stories of the ancients. The heroes who crossed the frozen sea needed not to be feared. They needed no praise to be great. They had will. Now we lack power. and less will than we admit. Perhaps this way of living is not our curse. Perhaps it is our excuse.

Fourth Letter — Confession

Tonight I refused to run with the others. I said the wounds of battle kept me from the fight. It was a lie. The truth is I fear what I am becoming when I cease to remember my own name in the midst of the bloodbath. These battle brothers do not want glory. They do not want brotherhood. They do not want remembrance. It wants only the moment. And if a warrior's life is made of moments without memory, then we are no longer heirs of heroes. We are only storms of flesh.

Last Letter — Never Delivered

If you read these words, I will have already made my choice. I do not renounce the strength that was given to me. But I cannot accept that it will define what I am after death. One day they will still sing of us. They will say we were invincible. That we were blessed. I hope they will also say that one of us had the courage to fear his own victory. Because not all battles are fought with fangs. Some are fought by remembering we are men.

Hroldar